

I'm 44. Here's What I Wish I Knew at 20

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Sep 16, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G8BqOPoJflk> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter, online fitness entrepreneur and self-made multi-millionaire, shares 10 brutally practical lessons on accelerating wealth and success — covering work ethic, environment, performance drugs, emotional control, and mentorship.

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Lesson 1: Push to Maximum, Not Minimum 0:50

- Most people ask "what's the least I can do?" — Brandon says the winning question is "what's the most I can do?"
 - The minimum-effort crowd always has excuses for why nothing works
 - Bare minimum reps, bare minimum hours — none of it produces extreme outcomes
- **His own story:** At 24, his father shot himself. Then the 2008 financial crisis hit simultaneously
 - Unemployment exceeded 10%; he couldn't find work despite having a college degree
 - Daily grind he built from scratch:
 - Woke up at 4:00 a.m. to train clients at a gym on 145th Street in Harlem
 - Showered at the gym, took the F train to Soho
 - Worked 8-hour shifts as a security guard at the Prada store (standing, opening doors)
 - After that shift, worked for a moving company
 - On weekends: trained clients in the morning, then managed a barbecue restaurant in Queens on Steinway Street

- This schedule ran **12–14 hour days, 7 days a week, for roughly 2 years**
- Result: he dug his family out of financial hardship and accumulated enough capital to start a business
- He eventually built an online fitness training business — one of the first ever, starting around 2009–2010
 - Grew it to a **7-figure then multi-7-figure business**
 - Has since taught **over 15,000 people** to grow successful online fitness businesses
- Student example — Jen Caesar:
 - Former nurse with two young kids and a husband
 - Started part-time while working 40-hour weeks full-time
 - Made **\$500,000 in her first year** as an online trainer
 - Eventually quit nursing because her fitness business income exceeded her salary

"The only reason I got out of that is because I was able to start my online fitness business... and I took that same work ethic and applied it."

Lesson 2: Your Environment Is Stronger Than Your Willpower [0:545](#)

- Environment quietly sets your standards for what is "normal" — and your standards drift toward whatever surrounds you
 - Your accent, clothing style, political beliefs, religion — most came from your environment, not your DNA
 - "If you get around the wrong people... your standards will start to drop almost automatically"
- **The social contagion study:**
 - If a friend gets fat, you have a **40% chance** of getting fat too
 - If a friend-of-a-friend (someone you don't even know) gets fat, you still have a **20% chance** — shown across a long-term academic study
- Practical steps to change your environment:
 - **Change your physical location** — Brandon left the South Side of Chicago permanently when he went to college
 - Moved to Forest Hills, Queens (where Donald Trump and Spider-Man's fictional Peter Parker are from)
 - Lived in a small apartment, but deliberately near mansions — would ride his bike or walk through wealthy neighborhoods to make the possibility feel real
 - **Change the people around you** — be deliberate about your circle
 - Join organizations, masterminds, mentorships with like-minded or already-successful people
 - You'll start adopting their beliefs about what's possible the same way you adopted your accent
- Bible analogy: Peter walking on water
 - Peter was an ordinary man — "his parents had to [have sex] for him to get born"
 - He walked on water because he saw Jesus doing it and believed it was possible

- Point: **lack of motivation is often a lack of belief**, not a lack of discipline
- When you're physically near someone doing what you want to do, belief becomes real and motivation follows naturally

Lesson 3: Performance-Enhancing Drugs (The Real Stack) 1:037

- Disclaimer (repeated multiple times): *Talk to your doctor before doing anything. This is personal experience only, not medical advice.*
- Prerequisite: all of this only makes sense **after** you've already optimized the basics
 - Get enough sleep, eat right, exercise — reach your natural optimal first
 - Using these without the basics just brings you up to "regular" — not exceptional
- His stack, in order of escalation:

Substance	Details	Notes
Caffeine	Up to 1,000 mg/day (worked up to it); Dr. Huberman takes ~800 mg	Cognitive enhancer; cheat code baseline
Nicotine	Nicotine patch worn on the hip during intense work sessions	"Potent nootropic" — provides continuous, sustained focus; not cigarettes
Adderall	Prescription amphetamine; never more than 2 days in a row ; takes whole months off	Very effective but highly addictive — withdrawal caused 2 weeks of depression/fatigue
Modafinil	Anti-narcolepsy medication; alternates with Adderall; used more frequently but not daily	Provides alertness without Adderall's intensity; sometimes prefers it depending on the task
Psilocybin (micro-dose)	Mentioned by high-level entrepreneur friends; tried it himself	Hardest to obtain legally; intense focus reported; available openly in Toronto stores

- Strategy for Adderall/Modafinil: **alternate them** to reduce addiction to either one
- "The first year I made my first million, I was high off stimulants... I had to put out a superhuman amount of output"
- Less than **5% of businesses** that survive ever reach \$1 million in revenue; 70–80% of businesses fail entirely
- "If you're not cheating, you're not trying"

Lesson 4: Your Emotions Are Your Responsibility 1:527

- Letting outside events control your emotions is weakness — "your emotions don't have to be a conditional response to life"
 - Examples of pointless emotional reactions: flight delays, traffic, someone's Instagram post

- Save emotional reactions for genuinely significant events ("if you get your arms chopped off, yeah, you're probably going to be sad")
- Brandon has **bipolar II disorder** (diagnosed) but manages it without medication using the tools below
 - His doctor confirmed medication isn't necessary given how stable he's become
- **Three ways to control your emotional state:**
 - **1. Physiology** — how you hold and move your body
 - Slouching and curling inward literally changes neurochemistry, triggering sadness
 - Sitting/standing upright and confident changes how you feel within ~2 minutes
 - Motion creates emotion
 - Brandon has a **trampoline on one of his balconies** — bounces on it to instantly reset his state
 - In his old New York office, he'd make the whole team stop and jump on the balcony trampoline when the energy was off
 - "You cannot jump on a trampoline and stay in a bad mood" — also trampolines and jet skis are his two guaranteed mood-lifters
 - **2. Environment** — people and physical surroundings
 - Emotions are contagious — one negative person can shift an entire room's energy
 - Conversely, a joyful person, a puppy, or a happy child can flip the energy instantly
 - Brandon takes long morning walks along the Atlantic Ocean at sunrise to deliberately start his day in a great state
 - **3. Thoughts** — the most important lever
 - Whatever you think about, you will feel — real or imagined
 - Demonstration: imagining your pet dying will make you sad even though it didn't happen
 - He focuses on goals, what's good, and where he's going — not on problems or worst-case scenarios

Lesson 5: Money Won't Make You Happy — And It's Not Supposed To 1:942

- People who say "money didn't make me happy" misunderstood money's function
 - "Money's only job is to be exchanged for goods and services"
 - Expecting money to manage your emotions is outsourcing your emotional responsibility to an inanimate object
- **Money is fertilizer analogy:**
 - Roses + fertilizer = bigger, stronger roses
 - Weeds + fertilizer = bigger weeds
 - Money amplifies what's already there — it doesn't install anything new
- One legitimate caveat: below a certain income threshold, it's genuinely hard to be happy
 - If you can't feed your kids or heat your home, basic needs deprivation creates real unhappiness
 - **After basic needs are met**, more money stops correlating with happiness

- Happiness isn't a permanent destination — everyone experiences the full emotional range regardless of wealth
 - "I've seen homeless people sing and dance. I've seen rich people cry."
 - The realistic goal is to raise your **average emotional baseline**, not achieve permanent bliss
 - "Get happy and make money" — not "make money to get happy"
- Emotions are always on a spectrum; no version of success removes all stress and dilemmas

Lesson 6: Focus on Inputs, Not Results [2:228](#)

- Championship performances, shredded physiques, and million-dollar businesses are just visible outputs of invisible, consistent inputs over time
- **The math of fat loss:**
 - Track calories burned (e.g., Apple Watch) and calories consumed (e.g., MyFitnessPal)
 - Every pound of fat = **3,500 calories** deficit
 - Burning 1,000 calories more than you consume daily = **2 lbs of fat lost per week**
 - To lose 10 lbs: ~5 weeks at that deficit — no scale-checking needed if inputs are tracked
- **The math of becoming a millionaire:**
 - Start at age 20; target \$1 million by age 40
 - Save and invest an extra **\$2,000/month** into the S&P 500 (historical average annual return: ~10%)
 - After 20 years: **\$1.3 million**
 - "Life is just math"
- Things that do NOT matter as inputs (Brandon's critique):
 - Making your bed, no-fap, cold showers — "male astrology"
 - Do them if you enjoy them, but they don't drive outcomes
 - "I might have made my bed two or three times in the last 5 years"
- Real inputs: enough outreach, consistent posting, proper follow-up, hitting calories and macros
- **Sample size problem:** a community member complained that 3 of 4 sales calls were unqualified
 - Brandon's response: "That number is not even statistically relevant"
 - Analogy: Steph Curry missing 2 of 4 three-point attempts doesn't mean he's bad
 - You need a large enough sample before drawing conclusions — just keep doing the right inputs
- Chef analogy: a chef at a good restaurant has to perform at top level every single service because the secret food critic could come any night — consistent standards mean you're always ready
- Brandon stopped weighing himself regularly because he tracks macros and calories every day without exception — "I know what's going to happen"

Lesson 7: Train Your Focus Like a Muscle [2:666](#)

- Focus is a trainable skill, not a fixed trait — difficulty focusing means you haven't trained it yet

- **Brandon's meditation practice:**
 - **Two 20-minute sessions per day** — once first thing in the morning, once in early afternoon
 - Over **20+ years** of this practice
 - No apps — just silence, eyes closed, focus on breath
- How the training works:
 - Focus on your breath; when your mind wanders (and it will), bring it back
 - Each time you catch the wander and return focus = **one rep**, like a barbell curl
 - Don't get frustrated when your mind wanders — getting excited that you caught it is the correct response
 - The practice IS the returning, not the perfect stillness
- Tim Ferriss stat: across hundreds of interviews with billionaires, CEOs, and elite performers, approximately **95% of them meditate**
- Brandon's view: the primary benefit isn't relaxation or stress relief — it's **learning to direct and sustain focus**
- Combined with his stimulant stack on top of 20 years of meditation training = "next level" output
- "Focus is a superpower" — lighthouse analogy: it doesn't try to illuminate the whole ocean, just one narrow beam at a time

Lesson 8: Intensity Over Balance 2:850

- "Balance" talk comes from two types of people: those who already got rich and can afford it, or those who will never get rich
- Extreme goals require extreme action — you cannot balance your way to extreme success
- **What Brandon sacrificed during his first million-dollar year:**
 - Missed every party, every barbecue, every birthday gathering
 - Didn't go to the movies once
 - Watched no NFL football, no NBA basketball
 - "I'm Black, so you know how difficult that was for me"
- Thanos analogy from *Avengers: Infinity War* — "What did it cost you?" "Everything."
- The payoff: once you reach the goal, you get a **better version** of everything you sacrificed
 - Sacrificed watching NBA on TV → now goes **courtside** to Miami Heat games (he lives across from the arena, goes with his friend Jeremy)
 - Sacrificed going to parties → now flies **first class** everywhere and gets **paid to speak** at events instead of just attending them
- Core framework:
 - You will sacrifice either way
 - Option A: sacrifice what you want *now*
 - Option B: sacrifice what you want *most* (your long-term goals)
 - Choose one — but choosing Option A leads to a better version of Option B later

- Movie analogy: no hero film shows a protagonist achieving greatness through balance
 - James Bond, Batman — none of them were balanced en route to the mission
 - Tony Stark is the closest example, but he was born a genius AND born rich — not applicable to most people



Lesson 9: Get Around People Who've Already Done It 3:090

- A mentor compresses time — instead of years of trial and error, they tell you what to do directly
- **Elliot Hulse story:**
 - When Brandon met him, Elliot had just hit **1 million YouTube subscribers** — organically, no paid ads, first fitness creator to do so
 - Elliot came to New York for a wedding, they smoked cigars, had a conversation
 - Elliot shared one piece of advice about something that had made him money
 - Brandon implemented it immediately → made **\$10,000 the following week**
 - Kept doing that same thing → earned **close to \$100,000** from it
 - This was ~15 years ago when that was substantial money
 - "I made 10 grand off of one conversation with Elliot Hulse"
- **Star Wars / Luke Skywalker analogy:**
 - Luke had raw talent but needed Obi-Wan, then Yoda
 - Training with Yoda (a Jedi Master) compressed years of skill development
 - Even in a movie with space magic and green aliens, the writers knew it would be *too unrealistic* for Luke to get great without a mentor
- The mentor-mentee relationship is "the only form of learning that doesn't fail"
 - Reading a book about swimming doesn't make you Michael Phelps
 - Asking ChatGPT how to play like LeBron doesn't get you to the NBA
 - You need someone to evaluate you and give real-time feedback
- Tim Grover coaching Michael Jordan analogy: constant feedback → faster improvement
- How to get a mentor:
 - Pay one if you have to
 - Work for one
 - Make friends with them
 - Join a community where the mentor is accessible



Promotional Segments 3:413

- Brandon promotes his **High Ticket Trainer** community (mentioned multiple times throughout)
 - Teaches online fitness entrepreneurs how to grow and monetize
 - Has taught 15,000+ people; students start making money quickly compared to his early DIY path

- Offers live coaching, content audits (Instagram and YouTube), and sales call reviews
- **Free live training** advertised:
 - How to make an extra **\$300–\$500/month** as an online trainer
 - Free AI tools (including ones he built himself)
 - Live Q&A before, during, and after
 - Personalized game plan for part-time or full-time online training
 - Live Instagram and YouTube audits during the call
 - Registration link in video description; 100% free